

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GREENLAND

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in Greenland, and one small town on a southern fjord proved it against one of the largest mining prizes on Earth. Just eight kilometres from **Narsaq** — a close-knit community of about a thousand people who live by fishing, sheep farming, and the harvest of the land and sea — lay **Kuannersuit**, known in Danish as **Kvanefjeld**: one of the world's greatest deposits of rare-earth metals, the elements that drive electric motors and wind turbines and weapons. But the ore was laced with **uranium and thorium**, and to mine it meant risking radioactive dust and waste in a fragile Arctic where nothing washes clean. The Australian company that held it, backed by a Chinese partner, had invested a fortune and was, under the government of the day, on track for final approval. The people of Narsaq had feared it for years — "we rely on the land and the sea," as one put it, and "uranium dust would destroy everything we depend on." So they made their fear the country's decision. When Greenland went to the polls in April 2021, the mine was the question on the ballot in all but name, and the party that promised to stop it, **Inuit Ataqatigiit**, won. That November, the **parliament passed a law banning uranium mining** — and with it, the Kuannersuit project died. A town of a thousand, using a nation's democracy, had stopped a mine the whole world wanted. The scale of what was refused is worth grasping. Kuannersuit is among the largest undeveloped rare-earth deposits on the planet, holding the very elements — neodymium, praseodymium, dysprosium, terbium — on which electric motors, wind turbines, and modern weapons depend, and which China overwhelmingly controls; the Australian developer and its Chinese partner had sunk more than a hundred million dollars into it, and it was one of the few non-Chinese sources the West was counting on. The uranium ran through the ore at roughly three hundred parts per million, and the law the new parliament passed banned mining any deposit above a hundred — so the ban did not merely pause Kuannersuit; it closed it.

The Kvanefjeld fight teaches two things about winning in Greenland — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the wider public, the consultation and environmental process, the courts, and, decisively, the democratic and legislative power of a self-governing people — pressed together until the project was stopped and the law was changed. The second is distinctly Greenlandic. The decisive lever here is **self-government at an intimate scale**: Greenland is a self-ruling Arctic nation of some fifty-six thousand people, whose own **parliament (the Inatsisartut)** and **government (the Naalakkersuisut)** control its mineral resources, and where a town of a thousand can shape a national election and a single project can decide who governs. That, and the land-and-sea livelihoods that bind Greenlanders to their environment, give communities here a power few in the world possess.

But the same story carries an honest warning, and this guide states it plainly. Greenland depends heavily on an annual block grant from Denmark, and many Greenlanders see mining revenue as the path to the **economic independence** they long for — so there is a powerful, standing pressure *for* large projects, and the anti-uranium victory ran against that current, not with it. Only eight years earlier, in fact, that same current had run the other way: in 2013 the parliament had lifted a decades-old "zero-tolerance" ban on mining radioactive materials precisely in order to court rare-earth investment and the revenue that might one day free Greenland from the Danish grant, and between then and 2021 foreign companies had taken licences and laid plans. The 2021 vote was, in effect, the nation reversing itself — which is why the fight had to be won not once but against the weight of a policy the establishment had deliberately adopted. The company did not simply walk away: it pursued **compensation through international arbitration**, a claim reported in the billions, the same investor-state weapon that shadows resource fights worldwide. And Greenland's rare earths sit at the centre of a **great-power contest** — China, the United States, and Europe all covet them — so a local decision can draw pressures far larger than the fjord it concerns. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a self-governing Greenlandic community, and the countervailing forces of money, independence, and geopolitics it must reckon with.

Most communities do not know **HOW** to make opposition effective. They worry privately, assume "the government and the company have decided," and never turn their fear into a public and political force. They never rouse the wider nation, never use the consultation and environmental process, never document the harm, never make a project an election issue, never reach for the legislative power a self-governing people holds. They generate private anxiety without a public campaign. The gap between a community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage or numbers. It is method.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Greenlandic system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

STEP 1:	TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the decision and its weak point)
STEP 2:	DOCUMENTATION	(build proof of harm and of every defect)
STEP 3:	LOCAL OPPOSITION	(rouse the community and the nation)
STEP 4:	LEGAL CHALLENGES	(the licensing process, consultation, and the law)
STEP 5:	MEDIA STRATEGY	(make the fight visible and win the nation)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the consultation objections and the public argument at once; the roused community sustains the pressure decision-makers respond to; a strong stand at a public hearing is a headline and a headline builds a movement. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The Kvanefjeld campaign did exactly this — it documented the radioactive danger, roused Narsaq and then the nation, used the consultation process, and made the mine the central question of an election, all together, until the project was stopped and a ban was law.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Greenland's give communities a distinctive set:

- **Self-government at an intimate scale.** Greenland's own **parliament (Inatsisartut)** and **government (Naalakkersuisut)** control mineral resources, and in a nation of fifty-six thousand a single community and a single project can decide an election — as Narsaq and Kvanefjeld did. Under its self-government arrangement, Greenland took control of its own mineral resources from Denmark, so the decisive powers over a mine — to license it, to assess it, to tax it, and to ban it — sit with Greenlanders themselves, in Nuuk, not in Copenhagen. Denmark retains foreign affairs, security, and defence, and pays an annual block grant, but the mineral decision is Greenland's own — which is exactly why a Greenlandic community's campaign is aimed at a government and a parliament of its own people.
- **The democratic and legislative lever.** A self-governing people can make a project the issue of an election and can pass a **law** to ban a whole class of mining — the ultimate lever, used against uranium in 2021.
- **Land-and-sea livelihoods.** Fishing, sheep farming, and hunting bind Greenlanders to their environment, so a threat to the land and water is a threat to the culture and the economy at once — a uniquely powerful argument. In Narsaq, the fear was concrete and specific: radioactive dust carried on the Arctic wind onto the grazing land of one of Greenland's few farming districts, and into the water and the fjord that feed the sheep and the fish; and in a place where remediation is nearly impossible and the cold preserves rather than disperses contamination, the harm would not be a passing accident but a permanent condition. That is why the argument was not "jobs versus environment" but something the whole nation understood — the possible ruin, forever, of a way of life.
- **The consultation and environmental process.** Mineral projects run through the **Mineral Resources Act**, environmental and social impact assessments, and **public consultations** — formal points of scrutiny and objection.
- **The courts and the rule of law.** Greenland's courts, within the Danish legal tradition, can review the legality of licences and decisions.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers run with the current. The **drive for economic independence** creates a standing pressure for mining revenue that any anti-project campaign must overcome. The **arbitration weapon** means a company can pursue vast compensation for a stopped project, a threat that can chill a government. **Great-power geopolitics** can bring pressures far beyond the local. Greenland's **small administration** has limited capacity, and its remoteness limits scrutiny. And a legislative ban aimed at one harm — uranium — leaves other mining to proceed. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — leaning on the community, the livelihoods argument, and the democratic lever, and pursuing the conditions, the delay, the redesign, and the record that are often what progress actually looks like.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Greenlandic development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The mineral-resources process. Mining and exploration run through the **Mineral Resources Act**, administered by the Greenlandic authorities, with **licences** granted by the government and technical and environmental oversight. This is the core track for a mine, and its assessments and consultations are key objection points.

The environmental and social assessment. Significant projects need an **environmental impact assessment (EIA)** and a **social impact assessment (SIA)**, with **public consultations** and hearings — the formal openings for a community's evidence and objections.

The government and parliament. Greenland's **government (Naalakkersuisut)** decides licences and policy, and its **parliament (Inatsisartut)** makes the law — including, as with uranium, the power to **ban a class of mining outright**. This is the level at which the biggest fights are won, and where an election can be decisive. It is worth grasping how directly this puts power in the people's hands: because the government that grants a licence is chosen by the electorate, and the parliament that can ban a class of mining answers to it, a community that carries the nation is not petitioning a distant authority but instructing its own. In most countries a mine is stopped, if at all, by regulators and courts; in Greenland it can be stopped by the voters themselves — a difference that shapes the whole strategy.

The relationship with Denmark. Greenland controls its mineral resources under self-government, but Denmark retains foreign, security, and defence matters, and the block grant shapes the economics — a backdrop that can bring outside pressure to bear.

The courts. Greenland's courts, within the Danish legal system, can review the legality of licences and decisions.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from exploration, into **licensing under the Mineral Resources Act**, through **environmental and social assessment and public consultation**, into **government decision and, for the gravest questions, parliament and the electorate**, with the **courts** available if a decision is challenged, and only then to construction.

Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in. The earliest doors are the cheapest and widest: an objection at the consultation and assessment stage, the livelihoods argument, documentation, and the community. The later doors — an election issue, a legislative ban, a court challenge — are more demanding but real, and Kvanefjeld went all the way to a national ban. Find out exactly where your project stands on this path; that tells you which door is open now.

Follow the Ore, the Water, and the Money

Behind the project stand a proponent — a foreign mining company and its financiers, often with great-power or corporate backing — and the officials who granted the licence. Trace who owns and funds the proponent, who profits, who authorised it, and — critically in Greenland — **what it does to the water, the land, and the livelihoods** the community depends on, and **what geopolitical and independence interests stand behind it**. Two questions unlock most Greenlandic fights: **What does it do to the land, sea, and livelihoods, and does it risk lasting or radioactive harm?** and **Can the nation be brought to decide against it — in consultation, at the ballot, or in law?** The livelihoods-and-environment case and the democratic lever are, together, the heart of most Greenlandic campaigns. The two reinforce each other: the threat to the land and sea gives the nation a reason to reject the project, and the democratic lever gives the nation the means to do so — so a campaign that documents the harm and carries it to the electorate is pulling both levers at once. Build the livelihoods case from the first day, and aim it, always, at the nation that will ultimately decide.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts** review legality; the environmental and mineral-resources authorities supervise assessment and compliance; the **parliament** oversees the government and can change the law; and the **community, the wider Greenlandic public, and the press** watch throughout — the ultimate overseers who, at Kvanefjeld, turned an election and passed a ban. In a small, self-governing nation, the **electorate and the parliament** are the two overseers that most directly answer to the people rather than to the project. Each is a separate front, and a project that threatens the livelihoods, offends the law, and loses the public rarely survives pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one door: the same well-built file — the threat to water and livelihoods, the deficient assessment, the independent science — can go to the consultation, the courts, the parties and parliament, the press, and the electorate at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close.

A Greenlandic campaign’s power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the roused nation and the democratic lever as the two that reach furthest.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Greenlandic and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project threatens **livelihoods and the environment** in a way the public feels, whether the **community can rouse the nation**, whether the fight can be made an **election or legislative** question, whether there is a **defect in the assessment or consultation**, and — against these — how strong the **independence-and-revenue** pull and the **geopolitical** pressure are. Where a livelihood threat meets a roused public and a democratic opening, Greenland's levers are formidable, as Kvanefjeld showed; where a project is modest, popular for its revenue, and free of a signature harm like radioactivity, discount the figures and think in terms of conditions and scrutiny.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Objection at consultation / assessment	20-45%	during review	low	On record; conditions; grounds
Livelihoods & environment argument	30-55%	ongoing	low	Public and political cost raised
Rousing the community and nation	35-60%	ongoing	low	Political cost decisive
Making it an election issue	case-specific	to next election	low	Government changed; project halted
Legislative ban	rare but decisive	1-3 years	high effort	A class of mining outlawed (the uranium route)
Court challenge	20-45%	months-years	low-moderate	Licence or assessment overturned or conditioned
Media & national campaign	35-60%	ongoing	low	The national argument won
Against a popular revenue project	10-35%	years	low-moderate	Conditions, scrutiny, delay
All steps combined (livelihood threat + opening)	45-70%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Stopped, banned, overturned, or conditioned
All steps combined (popular revenue project)	15-40%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Conditioned, delayed, scrutinised; record built

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Greenland's real strengths are distinctive — **self-government at an intimate scale**, the **democratic and legislative lever**, the **land-and-sea livelihoods** argument, the **consultation and assessment** process, and the **courts**. Its constraints are specific: the **independence-and-revenue** pull toward mining, the **arbitration** weapon, **great-power geopolitics**, a **small administration**, and bans that leave other mining untouched.

A note on cost: objecting at the consultation stage, making the livelihoods argument, and rousing the community are inexpensive. Court cases cost more but are within reach. Making a project an election issue or winning a legislative ban takes sustained effort more than money. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is the patient building of a roused community and a national argument — exactly what carried Narsaq's fear all the way to a national law.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (stopped, banned, overturned, conditioned, or delayed)

LIVELIHOOD THREAT + DEMOCRATIC OPENING -- a signature harm, a rousable public, an election or law in reach:

All steps combined:	45-70%
Rouse community + nation:	35-60%
Livelihoods + media:	30-60%
Consultation + courts:	20-45%
Single step:	5-60%

POPULAR REVENUE PROJECT -- modest harm, revenue the public wants, no signature danger:

All steps combined:	15-40%
Conditions / scrutiny / delay:	more achievable than a clean stop
Assessment defect + courts:	the strongest legal opening
Single step:	10-35%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Greenland are **the roused community and nation, the livelihoods argument, and the democratic and legislative lever**, amplified by the consultation process, the courts, and the press. Kvanefjeld shows the ceiling: a town of a thousand made a mine the question of an election and won a national ban. But the independence-and-revenue pull shows the floor: where a project is modest, popular, and free of a signature harm, the public may want it, and the realistic aim becomes conditions, scrutiny, and delay. Most Greenlandic fights sit between these poles, and the honest lesson is that self-government, livelihoods, and the democratic lever are real and distinctive strengths — decisive against a project with a signature danger the public rejects, weaker against a revenue project the nation wants. Use the table to plan, not to predict: it tells you which combinations have historically done the most work and where to put scarce effort first. The single most important reading is that no row on its own is as strong as the rows run together — the community that makes the livelihoods argument, objects at the consultation, brings in independent science, and carries the fight to the electorate at once consistently outperforms the one that pins its hopes on any single move, and in Greenland the roused-nation and democratic rows carry the most weight of all.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The roused community and nation** — Greenland's decisive lever; in an intimate democracy, a community that rouses the nation, as Narsaq did, can turn an election and force the government's hand.
2. **The democratic and legislative lever** — the power of a self-governing people to make a project an election issue and to ban a class of mining outright, as with uranium.
3. **The livelihoods and environment argument** — the threat to fishing, farming, and the land and sea that binds Greenlanders and makes a project's harm a threat to the whole way of life.
4. **The consultation and assessment process** — the objections and defects at the EIA, SIA, and public-hearing stage that give the fight legal and procedural teeth.
5. **The courts and the record** — the legal challenge and the documentation that overturn unlawful licences and outlast a single decision.

What Greenlandic Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The nation can decide** — an intimate democracy let a town of a thousand turn an election. **Livelihoods win the argument** — the threat to land and sea is a threat to the culture. **The legislative ban is the ultimate lever** — parliament outlawed uranium mining outright. **But revenue pulls the other way** — the drive for independence favours mining, and a popular revenue project is hard to stop. **And the arbitration weapon follows** — a stopped project can mean a billion-dollar claim. The through-line: **make the livelihoods-and-environment argument the nation feels; rouse the community and the country; use the consultation and assessment to build the case; make it an election and, where you can, a legislative question; use the courts — and against a revenue project the public wants, pursue conditions, scrutiny, and delay rather than expecting a clean stop.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point. Vague opposition to "the mine" goes nowhere; opposition to "the exploitation licence for a rare-earth mine whose radioactive uranium dust would threaten the water, the sheep, and the fish that Narsaq lives on, granted on an assessment that understates the danger" is a case — the case that won at Kvanefjeld. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What does it do to the livelihoods — the land, the sea, the water?** This is the first Greenlandic question, because the threat to **fishing, farming, hunting, and the water** is both the gravest harm and the argument that rouses

the nation. Does it risk a **signature danger** — radioactivity, a major contamination, an irreversible loss — that the public will not accept? Establish this first and hold it at the centre of everything, because in Greenland the livelihoods are not a sentimental attachment but the actual economy and the actual food of the community, and a project that threatens them threatens survival, not just scenery. A campaign that leads with the danger to the land, the sea, and the water speaks a language every Greenlander understands; one that leads with abstractions does not.

2. What licence, assessment, and consultation does it need — and is there a defect? Does it have, or seek, an **exploitation licence** under the Mineral Resources Act; a genuine **EIA and SIA**; real **public consultation** — or is one missing, defective, or dishonest? A deficient assessment or a hollow consultation is both a legal ground and a public scandal.

3. Can the nation be brought to decide against it? Can the fight be made an **election issue**, as Kvanefjeld was, or reach a **legislative** question — a ban or a rule? In an intimate democracy, this is the most powerful path, and you should assess early whether the public can be brought with you.

4. Who is behind it, and what forces stand with it? Is the proponent a foreign company with **great-power or corporate backing**; does the **independence-and-revenue** argument work for it; is there **geopolitical** interest in the ore? Naming these tells you what you are up against and how hard the current runs.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which authorities and the government decide; who owns, funds, and profits from the proponent; which community and livelihoods are affected and whether they can rouse the nation; and which parties, lawyers, courts, press, and the wider public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a foreign company seeks a licence to mine near a fishing-and-farming town, with tailings and dust that would threaten the water and the land, on an assessment residents believe understates the harm, and with the revenue argument in its favour.

Working the five questions: the harm — **the threat to the water, the fish, and the sheep** — is the argument to rouse the nation. Does it have a genuine **assessment and consultation**, or a defect to expose? Can the fight be made an **election or legislative** question, as Kvanefjeld was? Who backs it, and how strong is the **revenue** pull? And the deciders are the government and, ultimately, the parliament and the electorate, with the courts and the press as pressure points.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the mine" to a target list: rouse the town and the nation around the threat to livelihoods; object at the consultation and probe the assessment for defects; test whether the fight can be made an election or legislative issue; document the harm to water, fish, and farming; weigh the revenue and geopolitical forces; prepare a court challenge; and make it a national story. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Narsaq stopped Kvanefjeld. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse dread into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — make the livelihoods argument to the nation, object at the consultation, bring in independent science, reach the parties, weigh the revenue pull — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin today. That is the difference the five questions make, and it is what turns a town's private fear into a national decision.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A judge, an assessment official, a journalist, a member of parliament, and — decisively — the voting public all move on evidence, not indignation. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Official Record

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **licence or application** under the Mineral Resources Act, the **EIA and SIA**, and the **consultation record**. Much of this is public through the assessment and consultation process, which in Greenland includes formal public hearings. Use requests to the authorities for anything withheld; a refusal is itself documentable. The gap between what the paper claims — a safe project, an adequate assessment, a genuine consultation — and what the science and the community's knowledge show is where cases are won. At Kvanefjeld, the assessments and consultations became the arena in which the radioactive danger was made undeniable. Read whatever you obtain against the grain, for what it concedes or omits — an assessment that treats the radiation as manageable without saying how, a plan for tailings that glosses over the Arctic conditions that make containment so hard, a consultation logged as

complete when the community's questions went unanswered. In a fight where the danger is as grave as radioactivity, the gap between the company's calm assurances and the physical reality is usually where the case is strongest, and it is often visible in the company's own documents to anyone who reads them closely.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth

Document the reality the paper may understate, and put the **livelihoods and the land** at the centre. Record the **water** — the streams, the fjord, the drinking sources — and the risk of contamination, radioactive or otherwise, with the help of independent scientists. Document the **livelihoods** — the sheep farms, the fishing grounds, the hunting and harvesting — and exactly what the project would do to them, because in Greenland this is the case. Photograph and date the **site and the community**, and capture **before-and-after** with your own images and with public geodata and satellite imagery. Record **testimony** from farmers, fishers, hunters, elders, health voices, and independent experts on the threat to the land, the sea, and the health of the community.

Layer 3: The Defects and the Dangers

Finally, document the failures of process and the gravest dangers. Is the **assessment deficient** — understating the radioactive risk, the dust, the tailings, the contamination, the irreversible harm? Was the **consultation genuine**, or a formality? Does the project risk a **signature harm** — radioactivity, a major or permanent contamination — that the law should not permit and the public will not accept? Is there a **defect in the licence or the process**? Each defect and danger is a separate ground — for an objection, a court case, an election argument, a legislative case, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Greenlandic fights, because here a project that looked approvable is revealed to threaten the water and the livelihoods with a danger the nation will not bear — exactly the case that turned an election and became a law at Kvanefjeld.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Greenlandic cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's particular danger or defect.

The Licences, Assessments, and Their Paper Trail

- **The licence or application** under the Mineral Resources Act — the exploration or exploitation licence and its terms, and how and by whom it was granted.
- **The EIA and SIA** — read them critically for what they understate about the water, the radioactivity or contamination, the dust and tailings, and the harm to fishing, farming, and hunting.
- **The consultation record** — the public hearings, the questions raised, and whether they were genuinely answered.
- **The company and its backers** — the owners, the financiers, the great-power or corporate ties, and the money invested.
- **The revenue and the deal** — what the project promises the public purse, because that is the argument you must answer.

How to Get Them

Mineral, environmental, and consultation records are held by the Greenlandic mineral-resources and environmental authorities and made available through the **assessment and public-consultation process**, which includes formal hearings — the crucial early window. Use requests to the authorities for anything withheld. Work with **independent scientists and the environmental and community organisations**, at home and abroad, who hold the expertise to test an assessment's claims about radioactivity, water, and health — expertise a small community cannot muster alone, and which was decisive in exposing the dangers of Kvanefjeld. Move early: an objection entered during the consultation, and independent evidence gathered before a licence is granted, carry far more weight than the same point made later, and the hearing and comment windows are defined and firm.

The Ground Evidence

- **Independent water and radioactivity data** — the streams, the fjord, the drinking sources, the background and projected radiation, mapped to the community that depends on them.
- **Livelihoods evidence** — the sheep farms, the fishing grounds, the hunting and harvesting, and precisely what the project would do to them.

- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the site, the community, and the land and water at risk.
- **Before-and-after and mapping** using public geodata and satellite imagery.
- **Health and contamination evidence** — the risk to health from dust, radioactivity, and contamination, assessed by independent experts.
- **Testimony** — from farmers, fishers, hunters, elders, and independent scientists.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the licence, the assessments, the consultations, the hearings, and every deadline — the spine of any court case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a farmer, a fisher, a lawyer, a scientist, a journalist, a member of parliament, and a judge — and, at the ballot, a voter — all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the company's experts challenge it. In a small nation where a single election can decide a project, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest evidence of the threat to water and livelihoods — is very often the one that carries the argument, and the country.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ROUSE THE COMMUNITY AND THE NATION

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Roused people do — and in Greenland, uniquely, a roused community can rouse a whole nation, because the nation is small enough to hear it. The Kvanefjeld fight was won when the fear of one town of a thousand became the decision of a country of fifty-six thousand. A Greenlandic campaign's strength is its ability to carry a local threat to the national stage, and to the ballot.

Phase 1: The Core and the Community

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people who will carry the work — and root it firmly in the **affected community**, because the moral force of the people who will actually bear the harm is the campaign's foundation, as Narsaq's was. Assign roles: licensing and assessment, documentation, legal liaison, national and political liaison, media, and mobilisation. Agree on the goal — the licence refused, the project stopped, a ban won, the livelihoods protected — and on what you will and will not accept.

Phase 2: The Nation and the Coalition

Then widen deliberately to the **whole nation**, because that is where a Greenlandic fight is decided. Bring in **the wider Greenlandic public**, for whom a threat to one community's land and sea is a threat to a shared way of life; the **environmental and community organisations**, at home and abroad, that bring expertise and reach; **independent scientists**, whose testing gives the fight its credibility; **hunters', fishers', and farmers' associations**, whose livelihoods and standing carry weight; and the **political parties**, because in an intimate democracy a project can become a party's platform, as opposition to Kvanefjeld became Inuit Ataqatigiit's. Reach, too, the international scientific and environmental networks that can scrutinise an assessment and amplify the fight. The Kvanefjeld campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — a town, the nation, scientists, and a party as one — which is precisely the spread a winning Greenlandic campaign needs.

A worked coalition example. Facing a mine near a fishing-and-farming town, the affected community forms the moral base; independent scientists document the radioactive and water danger; hunters', fishers', and farmers' associations lend their livelihoods and standing; the wider public sees its shared way of life at stake; and a political party takes up the cause and carries it to the electorate. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the community, the science, the livelihoods, the nation, and the ballot — the model that stopped Kvanefjeld.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and in Greenland they must also outlast the pull of the revenue argument and the long timelines of licensing and elections. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — an objection lodged, a scientist on board, a party persuaded, a strong hearing. Rotate the exhausting roles. Keep the coalition broad and national, since a Greenlandic campaign's power is its reach into the whole country, and guard against the split — the promise of jobs or a share of revenue — that a proponent will use to divide a community that needs the income.

Above all, keep the livelihoods argument at the centre, because it is the one that binds the nation and answers the revenue pull.

Phase 4: Showing Strength and Winning the Vote

Numbers and legitimacy must be seen — and, in Greenland, ultimately mobilised at the ballot. Turn people out for public hearings, community meetings, and peaceful, well-run events. Let the **farmers, fishers, hunters, scientists, and the affected community** speak, so the nation hears the threat in the voices of those who will bear it. And where the fight can be made an **election issue**, run that campaign: make the project the question, back the parties that will stop it, and get the vote out — the path by which Kvanefjeld was decided. The 2021 election became, in all but name, a referendum on a single mine: the party that promised to stop it framed the vote as a choice between the project and the land, and enough Greenlanders agreed that they changed their government to change the outcome. That is the distinctive Greenlandic possibility — that a project, if the danger is grave enough and the community can carry the nation, can itself become the question on which a government rises or falls. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the government, the parliament, and the whole nation — that the community and the country are united against the project, and to carry that unity into the one arena, the ballot, where a self-governing people has the final word.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE LICENSING PROCESS, CONSULTATION, AND THE LAW

Greenlandic law gives communities real tools, and Kvanefjeld proved that the ultimate one — the law itself, made by a self-governing people — can stop even a mine the world wants. You do not need a final ruling to win with them: an objection, a consultation stand, or a court filing halts a project, forces disclosure, and creates leverage — though, as Kvanefjeld showed, the decisive blow can come from the electorate and the parliament. Engage lawyers and the organisations early — but understand the tools yourself.

The Consultation and the Assessment

The first lever is the assessment and consultation process. A mineral project needs an **EIA and SIA** and must undergo **public consultation**, including hearings, under the Mineral Resources Act. Object substantively while the assessment is open, putting your strongest evidence on the record — the threat to water and livelihoods, the radioactive or contamination danger, the defects in the company's own studies. A deficient assessment or a hollow consultation is a ground to demand refusal or conditions and to challenge a licence later — and, in Greenland's open and intimate politics, it is also a public scandal that feeds the national argument. The Kuannersuit process included extensive public consultations and hearings, and it was in those rooms — where the company's assurances met the residents' questions and the scientists' doubts about radiation, dust, and water — that the danger was made concrete and public. A consultation is not merely a legal box to tick; in a small democracy it is a stage on which the whole nation can watch a project's defenders fail to answer the community's fears.

The Democratic and Legislative Lever

The second lever, and Greenland's most powerful, is **democratic and legislative**. In a self-governing nation of fifty-six thousand, a project can be made the issue of an **election**, and a change of government can halt it. And the **parliament (Inatsisartut)** can pass a **law** — as it did with the Uranium Act — to ban a whole class of mining outright, ending a project at a stroke and for good. This is the lever that stopped Kvanefjeld, and it is available in Greenland as in few other places: where a community can carry the nation, the people can change not just a licence but the law. Assess early whether your fight can reach this level — it is the surest of all.

The Courts

Greenland's **courts**, within the Danish legal tradition, can review the legality of licences and decisions and can overturn or condition them. A well-built legal case forces disclosure, creates delay, and builds the record. Be aware, too, of the other side of the law: a company whose project is stopped may pursue **international arbitration** for compensation, as happened after the uranium ban — a real consideration, though one that falls on the government, not the community, and one that a democratic decision of a self-governing people can nonetheless withstand. After the uranium ban, the company behind Kuannersuit did indeed turn to international arbitration, pursuing a compensation claim reported to run into the billions of dollars — a sum vast for so small a public purse. It is a genuine risk and a genuine pressure, and a community should neither dismiss it nor be paralysed by it: the claim is the government's to defend, not the community's to pay, and

the democratic legitimacy of a decision the whole nation took at the ballot is itself a powerful answer to an investor's claim that it was treated arbitrarily.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Objections go to the mineral-resources and environmental authorities through the **consultation**; legislative and electoral routes run through the **parties, the parliament, and the electorate**; and legal challenges to the **courts**. Get help early: Greenland's and Denmark's environmental lawyers and the community and environmental organisations know these procedures, the hearing and comment deadlines, and the strongest ground, and can advise on whether the fight can be carried to the ballot or the statute book. Help engaged while the consultation is open, and before the decisive licence or election, is worth far more than help sought after the doors have closed — and in Greenland, the surest strategy marries the legal and consultation route to a roused nation and, where it can be reached, the ballot.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a judge, an assessment official, a member of parliament, a journalist, and a voter in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a mine's radioactive dust would contaminate the water and land a fishing-and-farming town lives on, on an assessment that understates the danger. That one fact becomes:

- **A livelihoods argument:** the project would poison the water, the sheep, and the fish that this community — and this way of life — depends on. The argument that binds the nation.
- **A legal argument:** the licence rests on a deficient assessment and a hollow consultation, contrary to the Mineral Resources Act — grounds for objection and a court challenge.
- **A health-and-environment argument:** radioactive contamination in a fragile Arctic that cannot be cleaned — a specific, grave, and lasting danger.
- **A democratic argument:** a self-governing people should decide whether to accept such a risk — the case for an election issue and a legislative ban.
- **A media argument:** a foreign company's radioactive mine against a small Arctic community defending its land and sea — a vivid, resonant story.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Greenland the arguments that most often decide things are the **livelihoods** one, because it binds the nation, and the **democratic** one, because in a self-governing people the ballot and the law are the final word. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the assessment file and a claim made to the voters can be proven by the scientists; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts and the assessment authorities want the illegality framed precisely against the specific rule — the Mineral Resources Act, the EIA and SIA requirements, the consultation duties — with the documents, the scientific evidence, and the timeline that prove it.

The parliament and the parties respond to the will of the people and the threat to the shared way of life — the harm to livelihoods, the danger the public will not accept, the case for a decision or a law.

Journalists need a specific, verified, human story with a hook: a named community and livelihood, a documented danger, a live decision, and the David-and-Goliath of a small town against a foreign mining giant.

Voters, in whose hands a Greenlandic fight ultimately rests, need the argument simple, truthful, and clear: what is at risk, why it is not worth it, and how their vote can protect it — the plain case that decided Kvanefjeld.

The community and the nation need to see that the fight is winnable and shared, so it holds together through the long licensing and election timelines. Show it the concrete milestones — an objection lodged, a scientist on board, a party persuaded, a strong hearing, a wave of national coverage — because a Greenlandic fight is measured in licensing rounds and election cycles, and a community that can see steady progress, and feels the nation turning behind it, is one that will

still be standing when the decisive vote finally comes.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in a small, self-governing nation where the public decides, it is often *the* lever. Coverage raises the political cost of a project, reaches the whole nation quickly, and shapes the election in which a project may be decided. Kvanefjeld was, in the end, won in the national mind: the coverage of the radioactive danger to a fishing-and-farming town made the mine a question no Greenlander could ignore, and turned an election.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place and stake, a documented danger, and a live decision. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a foreign company's radioactive mine would contaminate the water, sheep, and fish a small Arctic town lives on" is. Lead with your strongest verified fact — the threat to livelihoods and the signature danger — and offer a human voice: a farmer, a fisher, a hunter, a scientist. In Greenland the story of a small community defending its land and sea, its very way of life, against a foreign mining giant is uniquely powerful. It is a story, too, that the wider world readily grasps — an Indigenous Arctic people choosing their land and waters over a mine the great powers covet — and that resonance can be turned to the campaign's advantage, bringing international scrutiny to a company's assessment and international attention to a small nation's stand. Tell it as what it is: not a technical dispute over a permit, but a people deciding what kind of country they mean to keep.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first — the affected town and its neighbours. Then, quickly, the **national outlets** — Greenland's broadcaster and press, in Greenlandic and Danish — which carry the story to the whole nation and into the election that may decide it; in so small a country this ring is decisive and reached fast. Then the **Danish and international media and scientific networks**, which bring outside scrutiny to an assessment, reach the company's investors, and place the fight in the global story of rare earths, uranium, and the Arctic. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. In Greenland the **national ring is decisive**, because the nation is the electorate. In a country of fifty-six thousand, a story carried on the national broadcaster and the main outlets reaches, in effect, the whole voting public within days, and a local danger becomes a national question almost at once — which is why a Greenlandic campaign should aim for the national stage early and in both Greenlandic and Danish, so that no part of the electorate is left out of the argument it will ultimately decide.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions and elections. Plan a sequence — the scientific evidence, the assessment defect, the consultation, the election argument — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record, in Greenlandic and Danish, so the story reaches the whole nation and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; in a small, close nation where everyone will weigh your claims, one exaggeration handed to the company can cost credibility you cannot rebuild. Verified, specific, livelihoods-and-danger-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that, at Kvanefjeld, turned a town's fear into a nation's decision.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the livelihoods, the science, and the law.

8A. Objection at the Consultation / Assessment Stage

To: the mineral-resources and environmental authorities **Subject:** Objection — EIA/SIA and licence, [project] at [location]

As a community/person affected by [project] near [location], we object during the consultation to its assessment and licensing. Our grounds, with evidence: (1) the EIA/SIA [understates/omits] the threat to [the water/fishing/farming] our

community lives on; (2) [the project risks radioactive/contamination harm] that cannot be remediated in this environment; (3) [the consultation has been inadequate]. We attach independent scientific evidence. We request that the licence be **refused**, or granted only on strict conditions, and that our objection be formally answered at the hearing.

8B. Letter to a Member of Parliament / a Party (Inatsisartut)

To: [a member of the Inatsisartut / a party] **Subject:** [Project] near [location] — a threat to our livelihoods and a question for the nation

We write about [project], which threatens the water, the fishing, and the farming that [community] and our way of life depend on, with [a signature danger — e.g. radioactive dust that cannot be cleaned]. We ask you, and your party, to take up this cause — to press for refusal or the strongest conditions, and, if the danger warrants, to support a law that protects our land and sea, as parliament did against uranium mining. We attach our evidence and welcome the chance to present it.

8C. Access-to-Information / Records Request

To: [the mineral-resources / environmental authority] **Subject:** Request for licensing and assessment records — [project]

We request the following records for [project] near [location]: the licence or application; the EIA and SIA; the consultation and hearing records; and the water and radiation monitoring data. These concern a decision affecting the water and livelihoods of our community. Please make them available within the applicable period; a refusal should state its legal basis.

8D. Instructing a Lawyer / Environmental Organisation

To: an environmental lawyer / a community or environmental organisation **Subject:** [Project] — legal options and the democratic route

We believe the [licence/assessment] for [project] is unlawful and dangerous because [the EIA/SIA understates the radioactive and water risk / the consultation was inadequate]. We attach the assessment, our scientific evidence, and our timeline, and seek advice on an **objection**, a **court challenge**, and on carrying the fight to the **electorate and the parliament**, including whether a legislative ban is achievable. We also seek guidance on the company's possible **arbitration** response and what it means for the community.

8E. Letter to an Investor / Financier / Backer

To: [the investor / parent company / financier] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and political risk

We write regarding your [investment in / financing of] [company] in connection with [project] near [location]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "would spread radioactive dust over the water and land a small Arctic community lives on"], and it faces [overwhelming local opposition / a likely election and legislative challenge]. We remind you that Greenland has stopped exactly such a project — halting one of the world's largest rare-earth mines through a democratic decision and a legislative ban. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and political risk, and we are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Letter to a Hunters', Fishers', or Farmers' Association

To: [the association] **Subject:** [Project] near [location] — a threat to our shared livelihoods

We write about [project], which threatens the [fishing grounds / grazing land / hunting] that our members and communities depend on, with [the danger]. We ask the association to stand with us — to lend its voice, its knowledge, and its standing to the defence of the livelihoods this project would harm. We attach our evidence and welcome the chance to work together.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National, Danish, or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the community / the land and sea]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear hook: [documents and scientific evidence] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a foreign company's radioactive mine would contaminate the water, sheep, and fish a small Arctic town lives on"], with [a decision/election] due [date]. It is specific, verified, and it echoes how Greenland stopped the Kvanefjeld mine. I can share the full file and connect you with farmers, fishers, and a scientist.

Could we talk this week?

8H. Statement / Petition to the Nation

To: the Greenlandic public / the government (as a public statement or petition) **Subject:** Protect our land and sea from [project]

We, the people of [community] and citizens of Greenland, call on [the government and parliament] to stop [project], which would [one-line danger to the water and livelihoods]. This land and this sea are our life and our culture, and a self-governing people should not accept a danger it cannot undo. We ask that the licence be refused and our way of life protected, as the nation protected it against uranium mining.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of an objection, a demanded disclosure, or an ignored consultation is itself evidence, and exactly what a court, the parliament, and the press will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the livelihoods, the science, and the law; attach your documentation and scientific evidence; and route them, where you can, through the community and its associations, the parties and members of parliament, your lawyers, and the national press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in Greenland that record feeds the levers that matter most: the roused community and nation, the livelihoods argument, the consultation and assessment, and — decisively — the ballot and the law.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Make the livelihoods argument — to the nation.** In Greenland, the threat to the water, the fishing, and the farming is what rouses the country. State it plainly, tie it to the community that will bear it, and carry it beyond your town (8H, 8G).
- 2. Object at the consultation and probe the assessment.** A substantive objection at the hearing and a records request (8A, 8C) put your grounds on record and can expose the defects in the company's studies.
- 3. Reach the parties and parliament.** A letter to members and parties (8B) can make your project a political question — the path by which Kvanefjeld was decided.
- 4. Bring in independent scientists.** Their testing of the radioactive, water, and health risk (Step 2) is what makes the danger undeniable — a single credible scientist can change a national argument.
- 5. Rally the associations.** The hunters', fishers', and farmers' associations (8F) bring livelihoods, standing, and reach that a lone community cannot.
- 6. Make it an election issue where you can.** If a vote is in reach, make the project the question and get the nation to decide (Step 3).
- 7. Reach the press.** A vivid land-and-sea story (8G) carries the fight to the whole nation and to the world.

Do only the first three and you will have made the livelihoods argument, put your grounds on record, and reached the political arena — the exact foundation on which Narsaq stopped Kvanefjeld. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: make the livelihoods argument to the nation, object at the consultation, reach the parliament. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, done early, put the decisive Greenlandic levers — a roused nation and its democratic power — into play, and they are within reach of a handful of determined residents with a clear argument, a well-argued objection, and a few letters to the parties.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Greenland's system is, by world standards, democratic and rule-bound — but it is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is distinctive. The greatest is the **pull toward mining revenue**: Greenland depends on a Danish block grant and many see resource projects as the road to the **independence** they long for, so the political current often runs *for* a mine, and an anti-project campaign must overcome not just a company but a national aspiration. The **arbitration weapon** means a stopped project can bring a vast compensation claim against the government, a pressure that can chill a decision. **Great-power geopolitics** — the global scramble for rare earths, the interest of China, the United States, and Europe, and Denmark's own role — can bring outside pressures far larger than the local. Because Greenland sits on some of the largest rare-earth deposits outside China, and because those minerals are strategic for the energy transition and for defence, a decision about a single mine near a town of a thousand can attract the attention of the world's great powers — courtship, investment offers, and pressure that a small nation must weigh against its own wishes. A community should understand that its local fight may be entangled in far larger games, and prepare to hold to its ground and its livelihoods argument regardless of who else takes an interest. Greenland's **small administration** has limited capacity to scrutinise a sophisticated company, and its **remoteness** limits outside attention. And a **ban aimed at one danger**, like uranium, leaves other mining to proceed. Where these tilts bite, the current runs against you — but real levers still work.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts, real and distinctive levers remain.

A self-governing people can still decide. Kvanefjeld proved that in an intimate democracy a roused community can turn an election and a nation can choose its land over a mine, whatever the revenue pull.

The legislative lever is still the ultimate one. The parliament can ban a class of mining outright, ending a project for good — a power a self-governing people holds and can use again.

The livelihoods argument still binds the nation. In a country where the land and sea are the culture and the economy, a threat to them is a threat all Greenlanders feel.

The consultation and the courts still constrain. A deficient assessment or an unlawful licence is a real vulnerability, at the hearing and in court.

The record and the coalition endure. What you document — above all the danger to water and livelihoods — and the national coalition you build outlast a single decision and can win the next election.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Greenland is, by world standards, hopeful — with the specific cautions named. Self-government, the democratic and legislative lever, the livelihoods argument, and the consultation and courts give a community real and distinctive power, and Kvanefjeld shows they can stop a mine the world wanted. But the revenue-and-independence pull runs the other way, the arbitration weapon and geopolitics loom, and a small administration is stretched. So diagnose your fight honestly: make the **livelihoods argument** the nation feels; rouse the community and the country; use the consultation and the courts; and where the danger is grave enough and the public with you, carry it to the **ballot and the law**. Where a project is popular for its revenue and free of a signature danger, aim instead at conditions, scrutiny, and delay — and remember that a self-governing Greenlandic people, once roused, has done what the mining world thought impossible.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Greenland is a small, democratic society with a functioning rule of law, and it is not notably corrupt — but its very smallness creates its own risks: a tiny elite, close ties between officials, politicians, and a handful of companies, and an administration too small to fully scrutinise a sophisticated multinational. So the danger here is less classic bribery than **quiet capture and over-closeness** — a decision shaped by a company's superior resources and information, an assessment taken on trust, a revenue promise that overrides caution. When a project advances not on its merits but through such undue influence, your strategy shifts: you stop trying to persuade a captured or overwhelmed decision-maker and start exposing and going around them.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture and over-closeness. An **assessment taken largely from the company's own consultants** and accepted without independent scrutiny; a **consultation treated as a formality**; a **revenue or independence argument used to wave away every environmental concern**; **unusually close ties** between the proponent and decision-makers in a small elite; and **objections met with reassurance rather than answer**. In so small a system, the tell is often the *imbalance of resources and information* — a well-funded multinational and a stretched administration — as much as any impropriety. One anomaly may be error; a pattern of a stretched or captured process deferring to a powerful company is the risk to watch.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where undue influence reaches. A **small administration and a close political elite** can be overwhelmed or aligned with a powerful company, especially where the revenue argument is strong. But even in Greenland, some bodies and audiences are far harder to capture: the **independent courts**; the **wider electorate**, whom no company can buy and who at Kvanefjeld overruled the establishment; **independent scientists**, at home and abroad, beyond the company's reach; the **Danish and international press**; and the **parliament** when the public has spoken. Capture and over-closeness thrive on the imbalance of resources and on staying quiet; your task is to redress the imbalance — with independent science and outside scrutiny — and to lift the matter to the electorate, the parliament, and the press.

What to Do

Do not confront and tip off a captured or overwhelmed decision-maker. Instead, **redress the imbalance and document the anomaly** — commission the independent science the administration lacks, expose the assessment taken on trust, the consultation skipped, the revenue argument used to silence caution — and take it to the audiences beyond the company's reach: the **courts**, **independent scientists** and the international networks, the **Danish and international press**, and — above all — the **electorate and the parliament**, whom a democratic, self-governing people controls. Pair the exposure with the livelihoods case, so the impropriety and the harm surface together. And use Greenland's strengths: the intimacy that lets a company get close is the same intimacy that lets a roused community reach the whole nation, and the independent science that a stretched administration lacks is exactly what a community and its allies can bring.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Greenland turns on the consultation windows and, above all, on whether the nation can be brought to decide against the project.

Early (Weeks 0-8): The Livelihoods Argument, the Consultation, the Nation

Pin down the project, the licence, and — first — what it does to the **water and livelihoods** and whether it carries a **signature danger** (Step 1). Root the campaign in the **community** (Step 3). Move at once on what is cheap and decisive: **make the livelihoods argument to the nation** (8H, 8G); **object at the consultation and request the records** (8A, 8C); and begin **documenting** the harm and gathering **independent science** (Step 2). Reach the **parties, the associations, and a lawyer** early (8B, 8F, 8D). This phase lays the foundation, and in Greenland the national argument begun here is what ultimately decides the fight.

Middle (Months 2-24): Escalate on Every Front

Carry the fight from the community to the whole nation and build the coalition (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **court challenge**, the **assessment and consultation** defects, and, above all, the **electoral and legislative** route (Step 4). Reach the **investors and international networks** (8E). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international, in Greenlandic and Danish (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — every objection within the consultation window — because those chances do not return. And sequence the rest so each lands when it bites hardest — the independent science ready before the decisive hearing, the national argument built before the election that may decide the project, the legislative case prepared for the moment a sympathetic majority exists — because in Greenland a fight is won by those who move early, carry the nation, and time their reach for the ballot and the law.

Later (Months 6-48+): The Ballot, the Law, and the Outcome

Sustain the community and the national coalition through the long timelines; keep the record and the coverage alive.

Pursue what is achievable — a **licence refused, a project stopped, a ban won, the livelihoods protected** — and, against a popular revenue project, the **conditions, scrutiny, and delay** that are the realistic gains. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped and a law changed, as at Kvanefjeld. Sometimes it is a project conditioned, scrutinised, and delayed while the argument builds. Both are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8 Livelihoods argument to the nation | Object at consultation + request records | Independent science | Reach parties
MONTHS 2-24 Carry it national | Arguments | Courts + assessment defects + the electoral/legislative route | Investors | Media
MONTHS 6-48+ The ballot and the law | Win a stop / ban / conditions / delay | Protect the land, sea, and livelihoods

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Greenland gives communities a genuinely powerful — and, in places, unique — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Self-government at an intimate scale** means a nation of fifty-six thousand, whose own parliament and government control its minerals, and where a town of a thousand can turn an election. The **democratic and legislative lever** lets a self-governing people make a project the question of a vote and ban a class of mining outright, as it did with uranium. The **livelihoods argument** — the threat to the fishing, farming, and hunting that are the culture and the economy — binds the whole nation. And the **consultation and the courts** give formal points of scrutiny and challenge. These are the levers that let a small Arctic town stop one of the largest mining prizes on Earth.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The **drive for independence** creates a standing pull toward mining revenue that runs against an anti-project campaign. The **arbitration weapon** means a stopped project can bring a vast compensation claim. **Great-power geopolitics** can bring pressures far beyond the fjord. A **small administration** is stretched against a sophisticated multinational, and a **ban on one danger** leaves other mining to proceed. No guide should pretend these away; in Greenland, a campaign must overcome not just a company but, often, a national aspiration.

So the realistic promise is this: **make the livelihoods argument the nation feels; rouse the community and the country; object at the consultation and expose the defects; bring in independent science to answer a stretched administration; carry the fight to the ballot and, where the danger warrants, to the law; and where a project is popular for its revenue, aim at conditions, scrutiny, and delay — running all of it together.** Do that, and against a project with a signature danger the public rejects, you can stop it outright and, as at Kvanefjeld, win a ban that ends it for good; against a popular revenue project, you can condition it, scrutinise it, and delay it while the argument builds. Do it as the people of Narsaq did — a small community that made its fear the nation's decision.

A last word on endurance and self-rule. Greenland's great lesson is that a self-governing people can choose its land and sea over a mine the whole world wants: a town of a thousand carried its cause to a nation of fifty-six thousand, and the nation, at the ballot and in its parliament, said no. The proponent counts on the revenue argument, on your smallness, and on the long wait wearing you down. Its advantage is money, information, and a national aspiration for independence. Yours is the deepest advantage a community can have — a self-governing people who, in the end, decide, and for whom the land and the sea are not a resource to be traded but the life they mean to keep. Play to that. Keep the file and the science, keep the livelihoods argument at the centre, keep the community and the nation united, keep the record and the coverage alive, and treat every objection, every scientific finding, every association won, every party persuaded, and every vote as a brick in a wall no mining giant can climb — and that a self-governing people can make into law.

The tools are here, and among the most powerful a community anywhere possesses, and Greenland itself proved them: a small Arctic town stopped one of the world's greatest mines and won a national ban on the danger it carried. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, endurance, and a self-governing people who choose their land — and those you supply, as the people of Narsaq supplied them when they carried a town's fear to a nation and made it law. Begin today, begin with the livelihoods — the water, the fish, the sheep, the land — and build from there, carrying the argument from your own community outward to the nation that will, in the end, decide. Communities before you have stopped, banned, and overruled what looked unstoppable — a mine halted, a danger outlawed, a land and sea defended by the people who live on them. What was won at Kvanefjeld — by a town of a thousand that carried its fear to a nation and made it the nation's decision — can be won again by any community that makes the livelihoods argument its country feels, brings the science the company cannot answer, and carries the fight to the ballot and the law. What was won at Kvanefjeld can be won again. So can yours.